



Golden moment: The 1975 title, under the leadership of Ajitpal Singh, remains India's only Hockey World Cup title to date.

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up attacks but not skilled in converting penalty corners. "That was the reason why Balbir *saab* chose me. He rubbed my cheeks and pleaded, '*Tu hee bacha sakta hai. Kuch kar de* (Do something. Only you can save us).' He had faith that I would rescue the team from elimination," said Aslam.

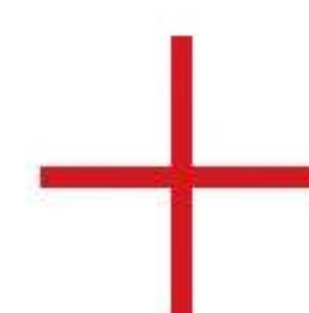
The game became rough and fast. India dominated the Malaysian half, but the equaliser remained out of reach. "I could not watch the game. All our hard work and preparation was slipping away. We played superior hockey but could not convert our chances. It was a difficult period for me," Balbir later said.

Four minutes from the end, Ashok earned India a penalty corner. The responsibility was now on Aslam. As he stepped up to take the shot, his

life flashed before him — his father's Olympic gold in 1936, his struggles to secure a spot in the playing eleven. "Somehow, I could never gain the support of the authorities. This was my god-sent chance," said Aslam.

Moments later, Aslam intercepted a Malaysian move. "I liked the feel of the ball on my stick. I felt confident. And then came the penalty corner — hardly four minutes left. I realised it was my moment, created by destiny. I spotted a nervous Balbir ji from the corner of my eye and then geared up for the strike, the shot of my life. I kissed the *taveez* (amulet) my mother had given me and prepared to take the penalty corner," Aslam said.

It was a moment to cherish. Govinda pushed the ball, Ajitpal



The 1975 team:

Leslie Fernandez, Ashok Diwan, Surjit Singh, Michael Kindo, Aslam Sher Khan, Varinder Singh, Onkar Singh, Mohinder Singh, Ajitpal Singh, Ashok Kumar, B.P. Govinda, Harcharan Singh, Harjinder Singh, Victor Philips, Shivaji Pawar, and P.E. Kalaiah.

The team has lost Surjit, Kindo, Varinder, Mohinder, and Pawar.